THE U.S. HEALTHCARE DEBATE: THE IDEOLOGICAL DIVIDE

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INTRODUCTION TO POLITICS: EXPLORING THE DEMOCRATIC EXPERIENCE

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I. Introduction:

The Healthcare debate in America can be traced back to 1912 when Theodore Roosevelt campaigned for National Health Insurance. Despite the attempts of many administrations since 1912, the United States has yet to enact legislation to provide universal healthcare insurance for its citizens. However, never before has healthcare reform emerged as such a contentious and divisive issue as it is today.

This paper argues that the current debate on healthcare reform is not about social policy-making aimed at repairing an economically unsustainable status quo. Rather, at its core, it is an ideological debate focused on a core value of the United States; namely, the appropriate role of government in the oversight of individual rights and self-determination.

The paper concludes that the United States is facing a political imperative in balancing Adam Smith's "invisible hand" principle of free market capitalism, as generally favored by Republicans, with a more activist role of government as favored by Democrats. This political balancing act may ultimately lead to new "New Deal".

The paper begins with a brief review of the history of healthcare reform in the United States and is followed by an analysis of competing philosophies on the role of government in reforming public support policies. The paper concludes by offering a

framework that focus on constructive, socially desirable outcomes that are critical to achieve the goals of healthcare reform. Good roadmap!

II. The Ideological Divide:

Harry Truman first proposed national health insurance in 1945. Sixty years later, the United States is the only industrialized country in the world that does not provide health care coverage for all its citizens. On any given day, 47 million Americans are uninsured and without affordable access to basic, necessary health care services; another 16 million are underinsured (*The New York Times Sunday, November 15, 2009*)

One has to ponder the obstacles that stood in the way of so many administrations for so many years to achieve the elusive reform. Jill Quadagno, a sociology professor at Florida State University, believes that the answer lies in the successful campaigns of special-interest groups against national health insurance and the inability of reformers to muster large-scale public support for their ideas. Quadagno, book *One Nation Uninsured: Why the U.S. Has No National Health Insurance (Quadagno .J, 2005)* describes in detail the history of America's failed efforts to address its citizens' health care needs (*Research In Profile, Issue 14, January, 2006*)

In *The Color of Welfare (*Quadagno J. 1996*)* she offers some explanations for our "unfinished welfare state". First the *Liberal values* thesis – advocated by Seymour Martin Lipset argues that social policy is America is weaker than Europe's because "we hold

pro-market and individual values and reject too much government." The second is the *State formation* offered by Theda Skocpol arguing that past experiences with major government programs such as the federal pension for widows and orphans of Civil war veterans resulted in such great corruption as to deter future administrations' forays into the welfare state.

However since then time and circumstances have changed dramatically. The Washington Post recently summed up the mood of the American people: "A majority of Americans see government action as critical to controlling runaway health-care costs, but there is broad public anxiety about the potential impact of reform legislation and conflicting views about the types of fixes being proposed on Capitol Hill" *(Washington Post June 24, 2009)*

Bruce Scott a Harvard Business School professor emeritus brought the current debate into sharp focus in a new monograph, The Concept of Capitalism, (Scott B., 2009-6 (Online),) Scott argues that the proponents of the Milton Friedman's school of economics are being faced with new challenges in these times of global economic crisis. They regard free market mechanisms as a way by which economies are self regulated. He argues that in cycles of boom and bust these mechanisms are insufficient and that it is the responsibility of the state to establish institutions, regulations that foster "competition with constraints set by a political authority." This seems to be the crux of the current debate and potentially an opening for a compromise.

The role of the federal government in major social and economic policies that have not been enshrined as constitutional rights has always been a subject of great debate.

Robert J. McKeever and Philips Davies in their book *Introduction to U.S. Politics (McKeever and Davies, 2006, Chapter 9)*. clearly outline the competing views of the role of the federal government in public support policies. They point out that there has been a traditional tendency to avoid U.S. federal government intervention in areas of social policy. Proponents believe that federalism and individual self reliance are the core values underpinning this view that is widely held by Republicans. The argument was that the determination of adequacy and quality of services is directly related to the cost associated with the delivery of such services that is ultimately borne by the beneficiary community. Therefore Republicans see federal government intervention in traditionally individual state affairs or free market enterprise as leading to increased taxes for the entire population not just the direct beneficiaries. They dub it:"distribution of wealth" if not outright Socialism.

McKeever and Davies describe a differing view, firmly held by Democrats, who believe that equality of opportunity in a free market society cannot be assumed for everyone, especially in times of economic crisis. They claim that opportunity must be underpinned by service provisions. They proceed to argue that: "government has an obligation to ensure that appropriate provision exist to support adequately its citizens in their pursuit of their target lifestyles and standards of living". Democrats would probably but not publically admit that tax increases to fund such services may be inevitable and they justify it in the name of social justice and equality of opportunity.

Funding is not even a consideration for those who view healthcare simply as a human right. Audrey R. Chapman's edited a book titled *Healthcare Reform: A Human Rights Approach* (Chapman A.R.., 1994 Chapter One). In it a number of distinguished

contributors call for a new "social covenant". They advocate the establishment of a "right to a standard of health care consistent with society's level of resources". The linkage between rights with limits creates in their mind a framework for seeking national consensus on a cost-conscious standard of universal medical care. This framework is not only rational but may in fact hold the key to a possible compromise.

Finally even Mr. Arthur Brooks, president of the American Enterprise Institute agrees with my thesis albeit he leaves very little hope for compromise.

"*The health-care debate is part of a moral struggle ...The choices will ultimately always come down to competing visions of America's future. Will we strengthen freedom, individual opportunity and enterprise? Or will we expand the role of the state and its power?*"

III. Conclusion

The (near) financial meltdown in the fall of 2008 must have served as a lesson for Americans that the "invisible hand" may sometime slip off the steering wheel and crash its passengers. By now it is commonly believed that without government intervention the U.S and indeed the global economy could have imploded. The analogy extends to healthcare. The U.S government cannot escape the obligation to mandate basic affordable universal healthcare coverage for all Americans. This in the final analysis is the compelling reason for narrowing the ideological divide in the name of core American values of fairness and social justice. Healthcare reform in some form or another is both

inevitable and imminent. But there remains the anxiety that members of Congress will be influenced by their re-election prospects and by the interests of their corporate donors and produce a weak legislation.

Or as Meyer and Canon (Meyer and Canon, 1999) aptly said: ***"individual rationality by legislators produces collectively irrational institutional and policy results"***

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Your analysis is good, but you need to work on structure - Please look up proper organization/structure for an academic paper in a writing guide.

Reference List *(Bibliography)*

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6. Meyer and Canon, 1999, *The Dysfunctional Congress? The Individual Roots of an Institutional Dilemma* Westview Press
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